Geotropes: Situating Postcolonial Bestsellers in the Global Literary Marketplace

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Overview

Conceptions of the literature of the Global South, and of India in particular, have been powerfully shaped by the work of a small number of well-known authors writing in English (Rossella and Srivastava 2017) . The possible distortions resulting from this limited canon have garnered significant scholarly attention in the past two decades, which has typically focused on how works produced by these writers are shaped by their own positionality as well as the exigencies of catering to an Anglo-European metropolitan audience (Brennan 1989; Huggan 2002; Brouillette 2007; Ponzanesi 2014). The concern expressed in such reflections often boils down to that of offering incomplete, skewed, or overly accommodationist representations of the cultures and countries being represented. A corollary of this position is that these same metropolitan readers would be confronted with a different, and potentially quite valuable perspective on the countries and cultures for which these authors have been presumed to speak, were they to encounter a broader swath of the writing produced by local authors writing in indigenous languages.

This presentation presents results from an attempt to evaluate and concretize this presumption by way of a computationally assisted analysis. We compare a collection of contemporary English-language novels written by authors of South Asian descent with a corpus of contemporary fiction translated from South Asian languages into English. Using a series of quantitative proxies for two qualities seen as typical of English-language originals — literariness and cosmopolitanism — we aim to establish 1) whether and how the works of the authors writing in English can be seen to constitute a coherent corpus vis-à-vis the translated works and 2) whether and how the former converge with literary fiction translated from two languages considered to possess high literary capital: French and German. By situating the postcolonial bestsellers within this broader context, we intend to provide a starting point from which to understand the differential pressures exerted by the “otherness industry” on literary production, as well as how reader perceptions of South Asia might be different if they were exposed to a broader range of translated texts.

Corpus

The corpus used for the analysis is derived from a much larger collection of translated fiction taken from the HathiTrust Digital Library (Erlin et al 2022). F or the purposes of the current study, the original collection was further curated to consist of four subcorpora: 578 texts translated from South Asian languages, 500 texts translated from French, 393 texts translated from German, and 62 English-language original texts written by prominent authors of South Asian descent. The final group of texts did not come from Hathi but was gathered independently based on conversations with scholars in the field. Each of the original texts are represented by ten 1,000-word random samples.

Methods

As mentioned, our analysis seeks to operationalize two central categories that appear in scholarship on postcolonial authors writing in English: literariness and cosmopolitanism. Literariness is of course a complex phenomenon, but there is an existing body of research in computational literary studies that engages with this topic and adduces a set of possible criteria by which it can be measured (Heuser and Le-Khac 2012; Cranenberg et al 2019). We have chosen to focus on five: mean sentence length, type-token ratio, intra-textual variance, concreteness, and a word-embedding based measure we term self-reference. We also mea-

sure cosmopolitanism along five dimensions. The first is a very simple proxy for metropolitanism that aggregates the number of times each document refers to one of the 500 largest world cities as ranked by 2023 population. From these single document frequency counts, we then calculate the mean value for each subcorpus. Our second dimension explores the broader geographical imagination of our corpus using named entity recognition. First, in a multi-step process, we identify and count all references to specific cities, countries, and continents in each document. In our version of this calculation, every reference to a city is also counted as a reference to the corresponding country or continent. We then calculate the Shannon Diversity Index (SDI) for each document at the level of country and continent. Widely used in ecology, the SDI is a measure of information entropy that provides a value indicating the dispersion (or diversity) of countries and continents in the books in our corpus, in a manner that also accounts for the total population size (i.e. the total number of geolocations mentioned). In simple terms, it quantifies the likelihood that we will be able to predict the "species" (country or continent) of a geographical named entity taken at random from a specific text sample. A higher index value means a greater variety of geolocations, which we equate with a higher degree of internationalism or cosmopolitanism. Our three remaining dimensions are based on word-embeddings that allow us to calculate the relative prominence of three semantic fields in our subcorpora: village life, kinship relations, and bodiliness.

Results and Discussion

Our results suggest substantial alignment with some existing conceptions of the character of postcolonial bestsellers, but we also find points of divergence that shed light on the specific market niche filled by those texts. Using principal component analysis (PCA) to plot two-dimensional visualizations for each of our analytical categories, we can see that the European and the South Asian translations form distinguishable clusters. The plots of the "bestseller" texts, however, point to a possible tension between the two categories. They are fairly widely dispersed across the plot for the cosmopolitanism variables but exhibit a tendency to align with the South Asian translations. With regard to the literariness variables, on the other hand, they appear somewhat more closely aligned with the European texts. This suggests that the postcolonial authors are, on the whole, more like the European authors with regard to the "literary" qualities of their texts but more similar to South Asian translated authors in terms of cosmopolitanism – a significant challenge to conventional wisdom. Zeroing in on the more granular insights provided by the results for the individual measures confirms and extends this hypothesis. The image of our postcolonial corpus that ultimately comes into view is one marked by similarities to European translations in terms of literariness and an urban or global orientation, but by similarity to translations from South Asian languages in terms of a preoccupation with familial relations and, to a certain degree, village life. In our introductory framing, we noted that an important subset of recent scholarship on this literature has attempted to map its location in the (primarily) Anglo-American literary field and to understand how authors position themselves vis-á-vis the literary market. Our approach offers a new perspective on this positioning. The argument is less nuanced (and less normative), but it provides an valuable additional angle from which to consider the particular market niche that these works occupy, suggesting that they align with Western expectations for literary fiction in regard to their linguistic and semantic complexity and their international orientation, but that they are distinctive, perhaps "exotically" so, in their focus on kinship relations.

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